# Chapter 15: the brief is ready

2026-10-24. The Researcher’s brief passed the Ghostwriter’s plan-only read on the second round: **no gaps**. A stranger could write the chapter from it. Full brief: `runs/ch15/research.md`. Nothing in it is verified.

# The plan, section by section (1,280 to 1,480 words)

| # | Section | Words |
|---|---|---|
| 0 | Opening: a callback to Chapter 14, one line of orientation, then the felt moment | 90-110 |
| 1 | **The zing.** Your confession of the pattern, then the household rule as the floor | 200-230 |
| 2 | **What she’s carrying.** The recurring pattern, her two lines, “Is that truly the case?”, the tantrum, the whole household | 300-340 |
| 3 | |

**The long game.** Chess over checkers, your two responses, Seneca “it takes two to make a fight,” “right or married” | 220-250 | | 4 | **Usually hers.** Kindness is not presence; a chore taken (unnamed), a foot rub, listening; Seneca “give quickly” | 220-250 | | 5 | **The best part.** Marcus I.9, the audit question | 200-230 | | 6 | The ah-ha, then one closing sentence | 50-70 |

## What the Ghostwriter will not do

It will not invent a date, a retort, a detail of her day, a named chore, or a child’s age. The brief forbids each one by name.

## Three things only you can answer (all optional; each has a default)

1. **Chapter 6 already prints part of the floor.** It has the “am I actually being lazy” check, the “she’s tired, she’s overloaded” reading, and a see-her-then-help line. You said “maybe we don’t need to use it twice.” **Default:** keep “Is that truly the case?” to two sentences and tell your responses as your own practice. **Alternative:** cut that question from Chapter 15.
2. **The ah-ha is my sentence in your voice.** “I was asking whether I’d been treated well. The better question was whether I was the best part of her day.” **Default:** keep it. **Or:** change it, or give the sentence you would actually say.
3. **A chore you take off her plate.** Every chore you named is printed elsewhere (coffee, wine, breakfast and the grill in Chapter 12; folding clothes in Chapter 6; dinner and bedtime in Chapter 8; cooking in Chapter 14). **Default:** it stays

unnamed, “one of the chores that’s usually hers.” **Or:** name one that’s usually hers and isn’t in the book yet.

## Where the spec and the brief differ (shown again at the verdict)

The outline wording I applied had a few phrases the voice rules bar. The brief declares each change: - “do not absorb it” becomes “stay steady yourself” (“absorb” is a flagged word). - The quoted “I see you” becomes your own indirect “tell her I see her.” Chapters 12 and 14 already use the phrase. - The sun image is dropped. The game (chess, checkers, the long game) is the one image, capped at five mentions. - Seneca II.1 only; II.2 repeats Chapter 12’s “She shouldn’t have to ask for everything.” - “Right or married” is a first printing, not a callback, because the Chapter 5

edit (#141) hasn’t happened. It’s introduced as “I tell people.” - “Floor” and “ceiling” are structure only and are never printed.

## Next

On your word I send the Ghostwriter to draft (`/gw-draft 15`), then the counted voice check, then the conformance check. If you’d rather answer the three questions first, say so.